

I clearly lack any village for a residence, I could not enter myself in the register of names and just walked in on my own.”

The Empress was pleased.

“Bring him into audience!”

The ladies of the court, receiving this order, took Blindman Shim by the hand to lead him into a detached palace. Blindman Shim was quite unaware. He entered the detached palace, frightened and unable to control his steps, and stood at the foot of the stairs.

She did not recognize Blindman Shim's face. His white hair had grown thin and the Empress, having spent three years in the Dragon's Palace, only dimly remembered her father's face. She asked, “Do you have a wife [2:33b] and children?”

He prostrated himself and answered as his tears flowed.

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“In a certain year I lost my wife
And was left with just my daughter,
Who was motherless in her first seven days.
Even though my eyes were dim,
I held the little baby in my arms
And begged her mother's milk to drink.
With difficulty I brought her up;
But steadily she grew apace.
Her filiality was native,
Surpassing people of the past.

chung mori

“There came a wicked monk, who said
My eyes would open and I would see
If I offered up three hundred sacks
Of sacrificial rice.
Your servant's daughter heard this talk.
Unable to sit calmly by
Without another course to take,
She sold herself to Nanking sailors—
While your servant never knew—
For three hundred sacks of rice.
As a sacrifice at the Indang Sea
She drowned and died,
At fifteen years of age.

“Not only are my eyes not opened
 But I have also lost my daughter.
 There is no place in this world
 For a man to live who sells his child.
 I pray you take my life!”

[2:34a]

The Empress listened tearfully. From the details of what she heard, she knew he was indeed her father. But, with the bond between father and child, how could she have waited for him to finish speaking? Actually, such is done to fashion a story.

aniri

He has barely finished speaking
 When the Empress leaps to stocking feet
 And dashes down to embrace her father.

chajin mori

“Father! I am really
 Your daughter Shim Ch'öng
 Who was drowned at the Indang Sea!”

Blindman Shim is astounded.
 “What talk is this?”

How glad he is!
 Suddenly, his two eyes—
 With a sound like a falling rain-hat—
 His two eyes are suddenly bright!
 The many blind men there assembled,
 At the sound of Blindman Shim's eyes opening,
 All at once roll their eyes
 With a crackling sound like
 Magpie chicks being fed.

All blind men's eyes are bright.
 Blind men who are in their homes,
 And eyes of blind women, too, are bright.
 Those blind before or after birth,
 Those half-blind
 And even those whose clear eyes cannot see,

The eyes of every one of them grows bright.
 For blind men,
 It is the dawning of a world.

[2:34b]

Blindman Shim was glad, indeed he was glad. But when he opened his eyes to see, this was, actually, a stranger. She said she was his daughter and, hence, he knew it to be so; but it was a face he had never known at all. Could he know her? Nearly expiring for joy, he danced and sang. aniri

"Joyful! Joyful!
 All sing praise!

chung chung mori

"However well Hsiang Chuang
 May have done his dance
 At the high feast in Hung-men,²³⁹
 How could he match my dance?
 When Han Kao-tsu on horseback
 Gained control of the world
 They say he did a sword dance well,
 But, oh-ho! Could that touch my dance?

"Ah, lo! People of the world!
*More precious the birth of a girl than a boy!*²⁴⁰
 To see once more
 My daughter Shim Ch'öng who had died—
 Has Yang Kuei-fei, who died,
 Been born again?
 Has the beauty Yü
 Returned to life again?

"No matter how you look at it,
 She's my daughter, Shim Ch'öng!
 Thanks to her, my eyes are opened—
 Again I can enjoy the brightness of
 The sun and the moon.
As an auspicious star appears
And portentous clouds arise:
*The officials all respond in song.*²⁴¹
 I see again the world of Yao and Shun.

“Joyful! Joyful!

More precious the birth of a girl than a boy

[2:35a]

Was said with me in mind!”

Innumerable other blind men also danced their dances, as innocent as newborns! aniri

“Joyful! Joyful!

chung chung mori

All sing praise!

“Oh, time! Oh, time! Do not move on!

Springtime that has gone

Can also come again;

But, when you and I grow old,

It's difficult to be young once more.

“It is said in texts of yore that

Time evades our grasp.

These words of wise and ancient

Mencius and Confucius.

What is there for us to do?”

He sang again, “Long life! Long life to Her Majesty!”

aniri

That same day, Blindman Shim was dressed in court robes and, following court etiquette, attended the morning reception. The Empress called him into audience again at the inner palace, where he expressed the lonely thoughts that he had harbored and told her every detail of Blindwoman An. Hearing of this, the Empress dispatched a palanquin to have An-ssi escorted thither and caused to be together with her father.

The Emperor commanded that Shim Hak-kyu be given the title, Father of the Empress, and that An-ssi be ennobled as Lady Chöngnyöl. Furthermore, he presented Lady Chang especially with much gold and silver, suspended labor duties for the people of Tohwa Ward, and presented much gold and silver to them to help others who might be in trouble. Thus were his commands. The whole world resounded with his benevolence, which the people of Tohwa regarded as great as the skies and seas. He recalled the Prefect of Mujang and had him promoted to duty as the Magistrate of Yeju.²⁴² [2:35b]

He instructed the magistrate immediately to apprehend Blindman Hwang

and Ppaengdök's mother. His orders were strict. The Magistrate of Yeju sent out an order to the three hundred and six jurisdictions for the capture and dispatch of Blindman Hwang and Ppaengdök's mother.

With the Father of the Empress sitting in judgment at Ch'önc'h'öng Hall, Blindman Hwang and Ppaengdök's mother were brought in. The Father of the Empress interrogated them on the spot.

"You heartless wretch! What did you mean by leaving—in the depth of the night and in the midst of endless mountain ranges—a blind man who was unable to distinguish heaven from earth, only to take up with Blindman Hwang?"

"I was led astray by the woman of a man named Chöngyön, who keeps an inn at the post-station."

The Father of the Empress, in a heightening rage, had Ppaengdök's mother drawn and quartered. He then called for Blindman Hwang and spoke to him. [2:36a]

"You merciless fellow! Are you not a blind man, too? You may enjoy luring away another man's wife—but the man who has been left, is he not to be pitied? Even though you would be what they call a 'butterfly mad for the flowers,' how could you have done this? It would be appropriate to kill you but, since I only send you into exile, bear me no resentment! I am doing this to forestall bad behavior and to prevent men of later generations from modeling themselves after such an improper affair as this."

Thus he spoke and gave his instructions. All the officials of the court and the people of the realm sang praises of such virtuous influence.

*Our progeny are prosperous and the world is at peace;
Empress Shim's virtuous influence o'erspreads the Four Seas.
We pray for a dynasty linking generations over many myriad years
And humbly pray that it be, indeed, an eternity.*²⁴³

The Empress addressed the Emperor.

"There has never been such happiness before; let us hold a Feast of Great Peace!"

The Emperor approved and let it be known throughout the realm. All the best dancers and singers were summoned, a place was set for the Emperor in the Hwanggük Palace, and all the officials of the court were gathered to celebrate. The kings of the various countries obediently presented the treasures of the world; and the best singers and the best dancers, sum- [2:36b]

moned from across the realm, almost all appeared. Embarked on an age of wisdom and peace, the people in every locality danced and sang.

“The lofty virtue of
Our heaven-sent filial Empress
O’erspreads the Four Seas!
Under the sun and moon of Yao
And within the heaven and earth of Shun,
The song of a boy at the crossroads meant such joy²⁴⁴
That the vast oceans were fermented
To make Great Peace Wine
And both sovereign and people were drunk together,
Joyful for many generations.
At a Feast of Great Peace like this,
Who would not be joyful?”

chung mori

While they sang thus, the Emperor and the Father of the Empress took their places in the Hwanggük Palace and called forth famous dancers and singers. After they had feasted for three days to the pleasure of high and low alike with songs, dances, plays, jests, and the music of harps and lutes, the Emperor, Empress, and the Father of the Empress all returned to the palace.

aniri

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The story changes.

[2.37a]

At this time, the Empress and An-ssi, now Lady Chöngnyöl, both became pregnant in the same month of the same year and then both bore sons in the same month. When she heard that her father had gained a son, the gentle-hearted Empress announced it to the Emperor even before her own. The Emperor, too, was glad and made presents of much fabric, gold, silver, and silk. He then dispatched an official of ceremonies to ask after their comfort.

The Father of the Empress could not measure the overwhelming joy in his happy heart at having produced a son in his declining years facing eighty. In addition, the Emperor had sent him gold, silver, silk, and fabrics and an important official to inquire! Awed and grateful, he prostrated himself with reverence and endlessly acclaimed the Imperial Blessing to the official of ceremonies.

And the Empress, further pleased, also conferred gold, silver, and treasures upon him and sent an official of ceremonies to inquire. The Father of

the Empress, even further gladdened, prepared himself in court robes and followed the official of ceremonies into the detached palace where he presented himself to the Empress. But while the Empress, too, had borne a son, how could he ever reckon the joy within his heart? The Empress took her father's hand and, thinking of past events, was both happy and sad. At this, the Father of the Empress, too, was saddened. [2:37b]

At this time, the Father of the Empress, following the official of ceremonies, was returning to his residence when he came to the foot of the Jade Steps. The Emperor praised him greatly.

"From what I hear, you have received a precious child in old age. He is, furthermore, of the same root and born in the same month and year as my prince. Is this not a happy thing? On another day, when he has become a clear and bright youth, I shall discuss the affairs of state with him."

To this the courtier replied, "In ancient times, Confucius said, 'To bear a son is not difficult, to raise him is; to raise a son is not difficult, to teach him is.' Let us wait and see."

He finished speaking and withdrew. He looked on his baby's face. It had a generous look and a handsome physiognomy that was truly modeled on men of yore.

Named T'ae-dong, he grew little by little and reached the age of ten.²⁴⁵ He was without peer in his intelligence and prudence and was skilled in literature and music. Could the love of his mother and father have been compared to holding treasured jade in hand? Pitiless time flowed like the waters and he reached the age of thirteen. [2:38a]

At this time, the Empress was intent on sending the Crown Prince off in marriage and proposed to the Emperor that the nephew and uncle born on the same day of the same month be married. The Emperor was pleased and ordered a wide search.

At this time, it happened that the Secretary of State, Kwön Söng-un, had a daughter with the virtue of a T'ai Jen, the talent of a Pan Chao and, in her person, surpassed the beauty Yü.²⁴⁶

At this time, the King of Yönn had a princess named Princess Anyang. The Emperor heard that she was of surpassing virtue and adept at every task. He ordered the King of Yönn and Secretary of State Kwön to appear in audience and, when they were in his presence, proposed marriages to them. The princess and the maiden were the same age of sixteen. Permission was happily given and the Emperor spoke to his court.

"How would it be for the maiden Kwön to be made the spouse of the

Crown Prince and for the princess of the King of Yŏn to be taken for the spouse of T'ae-dong?"

All answered him, saying, "That is proper."

The Empress, the Father of the Empress, and the imperial court were [2:38b] all pleased. The Emperor ordered the Court Astrologer to select a day: it was the fifteenth day of the third month of spring.

As a felicitous court event, the day was auspicious and a great feast was prepared. Lords from every locality and all the officials of the court stood as imperial guard in order of rank and the two ladies, escorted by three thousand ladies of the court who assisted on all sides, took their places at the nuptial dais.

The two grooms, like the sun and moon, were escorted by officers of the court. It was as if they were ushered by the attendants of Ursa Major. The brides were fair as May in red and green garments adorned with the seven jewels, every kind of ornament hanging at their waists, and flowered crowns on their heads.

First-rate beauties were selected from among the assembled three thousand women of the court to serve as escorts to the left and right of the two brides. Even Heng-o of the Lunar Palace could not have been more dazzling than this.

They met at the nuptial dais, where splendid, brilliantly embroidered curtains rose high into the void. The brilliance of the interior of the palace would be difficult to describe in a single word.

After the two grooms had each presented his mandarin duck²⁴⁷ and [2:39a] given silks, they both retired to take their places in their residences. On their first night in the bridal chamber by nuptial candlelight, they passed the night quietly in high spirits like mandarin ducks meeting on blue waters.

Emerging, it was the Crown Prince who first met the Secretary of State. The joy of the Secretary and his lady was quite beyond reckoning.

At this time, T'ae-dong, for his part, presented himself to the King and Queen of Yŏn. Both the King and Queen were pleased and boundlessly glad.

Soon thereafter, T'ae-dong, together with the Crown Prince, went forth to prostrate themselves at the morning court. The Emperor was pleased and called the Father of the Empress into audience to sit together and receive the first greetings of the newlyweds. After the court officials finished their morning audience, the Emperor spoke to them.

"Previously I had expressed my intent that T'ae-dong enter the court but that was before his marriage. Until now, he has had no official rank. What is your opinion on this?"

The civil and military officials all replied, "The man is excellent; we pray you instruct us immediately."

Hence, the Emperor forthwith called T'ae-dong before him and bestowed rank, conferring upon him the title of Hallim Scholar, Royal Tutor, and the honorary office of Third Minister of Personnel. The Emperor ennobled his wife as Lady Wangyŏl and presented them with much gold, silver, and fabric. [2:39b]

"You were earlier a student of classic texts and so had not helped in the governance of the realm. But from this day forward, as a remunerated state official, assist in the governance of the realm, as exhaustive in loyalty as in effort!"

The groom prostrated himself, then withdrew and went to see his mother. With what words could one describe her happy, joyful heart? Then, going into the detached palace, he expressed his gratitude before the Empress. Though overcome with happiness, the Empress asked, "How do you find your wife?"

T'ae-dong modestly shifted in his seat.

"I have found her chaste and pure."

The Empress asked further, "What rank was given you when you attended court this morning?"

"I received thus and such."²⁴⁸

The Empress, even further pleased, passed the day enjoying the company of the Crown Prince and the groom but, as the sun was setting, ended the feast.

"You must quickly proceed to your new homes!"

T'ae-dong replied to her, "I shall take her quickly and bring glory to my parents." [2:40a]

The Empress was very happy.

"That is what I would ask of you."

And so, for this day, the Crown Prince and the Hallim Scholar withdrew.

Several days later, the Father of the Empress selected a date and had Lady Wangyŏl move into her husband's home. The lady went before her parents-in-law and presented herself according to etiquette. The Father of the Empress and Lady Chŏngnyŏl loved and prized her like gold and jade.

A new detached palace was built where Lady Wangnyöl was caused to take up residence.

The story changes.

At this time, the Hallim Scholar by day made plans for affairs of state and at night devoted himself to studying the Way. There was no one who did not praise him, not to mention the grand and lesser officials and the common people.

In this way and that, the Hallim Scholar's age reached twenty.

At this time, the Emperor inquired into the Hallim Scholar's reputation and moral character through the court officials. One day he called the Scholar Shim into court and spoke.

"I have heard that your reputation and moral character are known throughout the realm. How could I begrudge you rank?"

He promoted him to high rank, making him President of the Board of Personnel and a member of the National Academy.

"Be a comrade to the Crown Prince!"

[2:40b]

Furthermore, the Emperor elevated his father's rank, entitling him as King Namp'yöng; he gave Lady Chöngnyöl An-ssi the title of Queen Insöng; he further added the title Lady Kongnyöl to that of Lady Wangnyöl, held by the President's lady.²⁴⁹ King Namp'yöng, the President's lady, and Queen Insöng all acclaimed the imperial benevolence.

"What good works have we done to be given such rank as this?" they said, singing praises of the Emperor for his generosity day and night.

At this time, King Namp'yöng had reached the age of eighty²⁵⁰ and happened to fall ill but even one hundred medicines were ineffective. At this point, no matter how the gentle and filial Empress and his good-hearted lady tried to cure the illness, a man to die cannot be called back. In just seven days he departed the world. The whole family was deeply grieved and the Empress, lamenting, also notified the Emperor. The Emperor spoke.

"It has been rare from days of yore for men to reach eighty. Please do not grieve overly."

The Emperor ordered that he be laid to rest in the Myöngnüng Gardens with the rites due a king and also instructed the Empress to enter mourning for three years.

When we think of the hardships the Father of the Empress faced when he was young, what lingering regrets can we have? [2:41a]

Ah! People of the world!

Is there a difference between then and now?

chanted

Think not lightly of men
By speaking of riches and glory!
Sadness follows the greatest joy
And sweetness follows the greatest pain!
Of all humankind this is true.
The fair name of Empress Shim
Has been passed over the years.